Two *for* the Row'd

FRIDAY NIGHT FRIGHTS PRESENTS

Haunted Ireland

13 spooky stories, myths & legends

CASTLES ◆ WITCHES ◆ BANSHEES ◆ THE DEVIL HIMSELF



BY NICOLA & PODGE ◆ TWO FOR THE ROW'D

Fáilte, if you dare…

Halloween was born right here in Ireland.

Long before trick-or-treating and plastic pumpkins, our ancestors marked Samhain, the end of the harvest and the start of the dark half of the year. It was the night when the veil between this world and the Otherworld grew thin, and all sorts of creatures were said to slip through.

Those stories never really went away. They're still told in the shadow of castle ruins, at the edges of fairy forts and around the fire on dark winter nights. So we've gathered thirteen of our favourites, from witches and banshees to a headless horseman and the Devil at the card table, for our new series, *Friday Night Frights*.

A new episode lands on YouTube every Friday evening from 23 October, and you can read all thirteen stories here first. Turn the lights down low, and maybe keep a little gold in your pocket. You'll find out why.

Nicola & Podge

---

01 The Devil at Loftus Hall · *Co. Wexford*
02 The Ghostly Jester of Malahide Castle · *Co. Dublin*
03 The Púca · *All over Ireland*
04 The Banshee · *All over Ireland*
05 The Witch of the Blackstairs · *Carlow–Wexford border*
06 Carlow Castle · *Co. Carlow*
07 The Children of Lir · *Co. Westmeath & beyond*
08 Duckett's Grove · *Co. Carlow*
09 The Dullahan · *All over Ireland*
10 Fairy Forts · *All over Ireland*
11 The Hellfire Club · *Dublin Mountains*
12 Alice Kyteler · *Co. Kilkenny*
13 The Rock of Dunamase · *Co. Laois*

CO. WEXFORD ◆ HAUNTED HOUSE

01

The Devil at Loftus Hall

On the wild Hook Peninsula stands Loftus Hall, home to one of the most chilling legends in the country. The story goes that one stormy night a handsome stranger arrived at the door and was welcomed in by the Tottenham family. He was charming and well-mannered, and he soon caught the eye of young Anne Tottenham.

Later, over a game of cards, Anne dropped a card and bent down under the table to pick it up. That's when she saw it: the stranger had a cloven hoof instead of a foot. When she screamed, he is said to have shot up through the ceiling in a ball of flame. Poor Anne was never the same again, and many say she has never truly left the house.

WHERE *Hook Peninsula, Co. Wexford*

▶ ON YOUTUBE FROM FRI 23 OCT

✦ ✦ ✦

CO. DUBLIN ◆ CASTLE GHOST

02

The Ghostly Jester of Malahide Castle

Behind the walls of Malahide Castle lurks one of Ireland's most tragic spirits: Puck, a small, mischievous court jester who entertained the Talbot family in the 16th century. Puck fell hopelessly in love with a noblewoman, and that forbidden love may have cost him his life.

One bitterly cold December night, he was found outside the castle walls, stabbed through the heart and still dressed in his colourful costume. Before he died, legend says, Puck swore to haunt Malahide until a master of the house married a woman of common birth. Visitors have reported strange shadows and even a jester's face appearing in photographs, and he was supposedly spotted as recently as 1976, when the castle's contents were being sold.

WHERE *Malahide, Co. Dublin*

▶ ON YOUTUBE FROM FRI 30 OCT

ALL OVER IRELAND ◆ SAMHAIN FOLKLORE

03

The Púca: Ireland's Shape-Shifter

The Púca is Ireland's most unpredictable supernatural creature. It can take many forms, but it's best known as a sleek black horse with glowing golden eyes that tricks travellers into climbing onto its back, then carries them on a wild ride through the night before dumping them in a ditch.

The Púca is closely tied to Samhain, the festival that gave us Halloween. Folklore warns that once the harvest is in, the Púca roams the countryside, spoiling any crops left behind and claiming the last wild fruits for itself. Yet not every encounter is sinister: some stories say it brings good fortune or warnings to those who treat it with respect. Still, if a mysterious black horse offers you a lift home tonight… you might be better off walking!

▶ On YouTube from Fri 6 Nov

✦ ✦ ✦

ALL OVER IRELAND ◆ FOLKLORE

04

The Banshee: Messenger of Death

The Bean Sí, the "woman of the fairy mound", is said to wail in the night before a death in certain old Irish families. Some describe her as a beautiful young woman with long silver hair; others see an old hag cloaked in grey. Either way, her keening cry is one sound nobody wants to hear outside their window.

She is often said to carry a silver comb, which she uses to comb her long hair as she weeps. And here is one piece of advice passed down through generations: if you ever find a mysterious silver comb lying by the roadside, leave it exactly where it is. The Banshee will come looking for it.

▶ On YouTube from Fri 13 Nov

CARLOW–WEXFORD BORDER ◆ FOLKLORE

05

The Witch of the Blackstairs

High in the Blackstairs Mountains, on the border of Carlow and Wexford, they still tell the tale of a Carlow witch locked in a bitter feud with her Wexford neighbour. One day her temper got the better of her, and she hurled an enormous boulder across the mountains at her rival.

But the effort was too much. She lost her footing and tumbled all the way down the mountainside, carving deep tracks into the slope as she went. Those marks are still known locally as the Witch's Slide, and the boulder she threw is said to stand in Clonee to this day.

WHERE *Blackstairs Mountains, Carlow–Wexford border*

▶ ON YOUTUBE FROM FRI 20 NOV

✦ ✦ ✦

CO. CARLOW ◆ TRUE HISTORY

06

Carlow Castle: The Fortress That Fell to a Doctor

Beside the River Barrow stand the remains of Carlow Castle, a 13th-century Norman fortress that survived centuries of sieges and conflict. Armies came and went, and still the castle stood.

Then, in 1814, a local doctor came up with a plan to turn the castle into an asylum. To make room inside, he decided to thin the great walls using explosives. It didn't go to plan! The blast brought most of the castle crashing down, leaving only the west wall and its two towers. Some castles fall to armies… this one fell to a doctor.

WHERE *Carlow town, beside the River Barrow*

▶ ON YOUTUBE FROM FRI 27 NOV

CO. WESTMEATH & BEYOND ◆ LEGEND

07

The Children of Lir

King Lir loved his four children, Fionnuala, Aodh, Fiachra and Conn, more than anything. But their stepmother Aoife grew so jealous of that love that she used dark magic to turn all four into swans.

The spell would last 900 years: three hundred on Lough Derravaragh in Westmeath, three hundred on the cold, stormy Sea of Moyle, and three hundred more on the Atlantic off the west coast. Through it all, the children kept their human voices and sang songs so beautiful that people came from far and wide to hear them. It's one of Ireland's most beautiful, and most heartbreaking, legends.

WHERE *Lough Derravaragh, Co. Westmeath*

▶ ON YOUTUBE FROM FRI 4 DEC

✦ ✦ ✦

CO. CARLOW ◆ HAUNTED MANSION

08

Duckett's Grove: Carlow's Haunted Mansion

The Gothic ruins of Duckett's Grove, with their turrets and towers, look like something straight out of a ghost story, and the stories certainly followed. This once-grand estate is tied to tales of a family curse and of a Banshee whose cries were said to foretell death.

In 1933, fire swept through the house and gutted it, leaving the eerie towers and crumbling walls that stand today. You can wander the grounds and walled gardens, but as the light fades on an autumn evening, it's easy to see why people say the place is haunted.

WHERE *Near Carlow town, Co. Carlow*

▶ ON YOUTUBE FROM FRI 11 DEC

ALL OVER IRELAND ◆ MYTHOLOGY

09

The Dullahan: Ireland's Headless Horseman

Long before Sleepy Hollow, Ireland had the Dullahan. This headless horseman rides through the dark on a black horse, carrying his own head tucked under his arm. In some tellings, his whip is made from a human spine.

When the Dullahan stops riding, someone is destined to die. No locked gate can keep him out, and anyone foolish enough to watch him pass may get a basin of blood thrown in their face for their trouble. But he has one weakness: gold. Even the tiniest piece of gold is said to send him fleeing into the night.

▶ On YouTube from Fri 18 Dec

✦ ✦ ✦

ALL OVER IRELAND ◆ FOLKLORE

10

Fairy Forts: Ireland's Otherworld

Scattered across the Irish countryside are thousands of ancient circular earthworks known as fairy forts. For centuries they were believed to be home to the Aos Sí, Ireland's supernatural fairy folk, and they were treated with fear and respect. Farmers refused to plough them, the trees on them were left untouched, and warnings were passed down that anyone who interfered with a fairy fort risked terrible misfortune.

Legend tells of strange lights dancing across the fields at night and mysterious music drifting through the dark. Travellers who wander into fairy territory may never come back quite the same. Even today, plenty of people in Ireland won't touch a fairy fort. Would you?

▶ On YouTube from Fri 25 Dec

DUBLIN MOUNTAINS ◆ HAUNTED RUIN

11

The Hellfire Club: Dublin's Most Haunted Hill

High on Montpelier Hill in the Dublin Mountains stand the eerie ruins of an 18th-century hunting lodge. It became linked to a notorious gentlemen's club rumoured to indulge in drunken debauchery, black magic and devil worship.

Its most chilling legend tells of a mysterious stranger who joined a game of cards. When one of the players dropped a card and bent down to retrieve it, he saw that the stranger had a cloven hoof instead of a foot. The Devil himself had come to play! Add in ghostly apparitions and a building said to have been set ablaze, and it's no wonder this is one of Dublin's most infamous haunted spots.

WHERE *Montpelier Hill, Dublin Mountains*

▶ ON YOUTUBE FROM FRI 1 JAN

✦ ✦ ✦

CO. KILKENNY ◆ TRUE HISTORY

12

Alice Kyteler: The Witch of Kilkenny

In 1324, Dame Alice Kyteler was one of the wealthiest women in Kilkenny. She had been married four times, and when her stepchildren accused her of using dark magic to murder her husbands and steal their fortunes, the city was gripped by rumours of potions, demonic rituals and a shadowy spirit called Robin Artisson.

Alice escaped punishment, but her servant Petronilla de Meath was not so lucky. She was tortured and burned at the stake, the first recorded person executed for witchcraft in Ireland. Seven centuries later, Alice's name still haunts the streets of Kilkenny. Was she a dangerous witch, or an innocent woman caught in a web of jealousy and greed?

WHERE *Kilkenny city*

▶ ON YOUTUBE FROM FRI 8 JAN

CO. LAOIS ◆ CASTLE RUIN

13

The Rock of Dunamase

Perched high above the Laois countryside, close to where Nicola grew up, the ruins of the Rock of Dunamase have seen bloody battles, Viking raids and centuries of mysterious legends.

Local folklore tells of treasure buried by the O'Moore clan somewhere beneath these ancient stones, guarded by a terrifying black hound known as the Bandog. Add in tales of mischievous fairies and strange happenings, and you have one of the most atmospheric places in Ireland. Is it simply a magnificent medieval ruin, or do its walls hide secrets that refuse to stay buried?

WHERE *Near Portlaoise, Co. Laois*

▶ ON YOUTUBE FROM FRI 15 JAN

✦ ✦ ✦

Know a spooky story?

A haunted ruin near you, a local legend, or a ghost story your granny swore was true. We'd love to hear it, and it might just end up in a future episode of Friday Night Frights.

SEND US YOUR TALE →

Happy haunting!

Thanks for joining us on the Row'd. We're Nicola and Podge, two Irish travellers sharing honest guides, hidden gems and the odd ghost story from Ireland and further afield.

Keep an eye on your inbox for our newsletter, and come find us here:

Watch Friday Night Frights
a new spooky story every Friday

Our Halloween picks
ghost tours, haunted cities & spooky trips

Subscribe on YouTube
@twofortherowd

TwoForTheRowd.com
destination guides from two Irish travellers

These are folk tales and legends as they've been passed down. When visiting any of these places, check opening times and access before you go.

